

# Editorial: Past, Present, and Future

“EachMovie: archaeology of a first latent recommender system”

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## Introduction

My ACM RecSys 2026 paper “EachMovie: archaeology of a first latent recommender system” [2] is part of that conference’s decennial “Past, Present & Future” track. My conference presentation includes extra bonus material not in the paper.<sup>1</sup> This Editorial briefly lists some of the new points introduced there.

*Warning:* The conference presentation includes this new material in a deliberately personal Editorial context. That same personal perspective continues here. This is all just my opinion. More research is clearly needed.

## 1 Past

As noted in the paper, EachMovie cultivated a high degree of user engagement and trust. Its users *wanted* to use EachMovie, and to help it model their tastes and their souls.<sup>2</sup>

EachMovie’s users were invited to write in, and many did [3]. One particular respondent wrote:

*I’ve been using it for two months, and it’s eerily good at predicting what I’ll like ... One of my favorite games with EachMovie is to enter a bogus rating, just to see how it affects the predictions; when I revert to my true opinion, EachMovie recalculates all its predictions instantly. ... A better predictor, and more fun to use. [7]*

The manner in which this user twiddled EachMovie’s knobs is like a textbook example of *human agency* [1] in an online system [6]. This human user (whom I recognized as a former colleague) could act intentionally; she could control her environment; and she could shape her experiences. In short, EachMovie *let her drive*.

The EachMovie team did not plan for this most excellent outcome. *Letting users drive* was an emergent property, but it was a very welcome one. This outcome was completely accidental, but I argue that this is exactly the type of outcome we should try to replicate in our modern recommender systems.

### 1.1 Letting users drive

*Letting users drive* is the important contribution of this Editorial. But read on anyway.

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<sup>1</sup>The final presentation video of 2026-09-30 is expected to take some time to replace the ACM Digital Library’s backup video from 2026-07-31.

<sup>2</sup>The reference to “souls” here is deliberate. Movies, done well, reflect the human soul, and they shape the human soul. This is true of all good art. I posit that latent recommender systems for humans have a similar *potential* to reflect the human soul (via their users’ votes as carried into its internal models) and to shape the human soul (via their recommendations to their users). I believe this is true regardless of our current systems’ massive shortcomings.

## 2 Present

That was then and this is now. Thirty years have passed. Those carefree halcyon days of the 1990s are long gone.

My historical paper’s Conclusions section was called “Back to the future” and it was boring. It arguably followed the similarly anodyne conclusion of that movie [8]. This new editorial content in the conference presentation was meant to be less boring, more closely following the plot of “Back to the Future Part II” [9].

In this light, our own current world can perhaps be viewed as a divergent timeline, as in the second movie. Biff Tannen<sup>3</sup> is running the casino,<sup>4</sup> and he’s dialing the figurative *doomscrollamine*<sup>5</sup> all the way up to 11. Ours is arguably the wrong timeline, at least for recommender systems and their users. We’re all doomed. Or maybe not. Let’s hope not.

## 3 Future

Yes, there are two paths you can go by,  
but in the long run /  
There’s still time to change the road you’re on.

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*Stairway to Heaven*, Robert Plant, 1971

What to do? I am not sure, but it “really makes me wonder” [5]. Perhaps the first step is to build our systems to help users drive again.

## 4 Summary

EachMovie let users drive. We should do that again.

## Acknowledgments

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## References

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<sup>3</sup>Biff Tannen is the movie’s bad guy, who gains excessive control over the dystopian “Hell Valley” by unscrupulous means.

<sup>4</sup>This is “Biff Tannen’s Pleasure Paradise Casino & Hotel.”

<sup>5</sup>This very recent neologism is from Andrew Marlton [4]. It combines “doomscrolling” with “dopamine,” the chemical that floods the brain following rewards, helping to create addiction via neuroplasticity. That is not a good combination.